



SYLLABUS FOR MGMP 543: CORE FINANCE

Spring 2026 Sections 1 (Mondays) and 2 (Wednesdays)

(This version: February 18th, 2026)

Course Changes:

This syllabus is a guideline for the course. I will do my best to conduct the course according to the schedule and policies outlined in this syllabus. I reserve the right to adjust the course (e.g., schedule, assignments, etc.) as we proceed as I see fit. Please refer to Canvas for the latest syllabus and any course changes.

Teaching Team:

Professor Benedict Guttman-Kenney

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Teaching Assistant: Amy Chen Qian

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Faculty Support Specialist: Luis Leyva

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Phone: 713-348-5326

Classes:

Section 1 (2) meets Mondays (Wednesdays) at 6.15pm – 9.30pm in McNair Hall Room 212.

Office Hours:

For an appointment with Amy, please email amy.chen.qian@rice.edu.

For an appointment with Benedict, please book on [Calendly](https://calendly.com/benedictgk). If no times listed match your availability, please email me.

I highly recommend emailing questions in advance to make the meeting most productive.

Objective:

This course introduces the core theory and practice “corporate finance” – how firms raise and invest capital. At the end of this you should understand the main financial decisions facing firms, how these financial decisions are related, and how to make such financial decisions.

Canvas:

All materials for this course will be available via Canvas. This should be your first stop if you are looking for information.

How to succeed in this course:

1. Do the pre-course Coursera.
2. Read the textbook chapter(s) carefully BEFORE class.
3. Come to class on-time.

4. Do homework problems. If you want more practice, try the end of chapter textbook questions. I've uploaded the solutions to canvas.
5. Ask for help. If you are struggling, there are plenty of resources out there. Form study groups, ask your classmates, ask questions in class, go to office hours.
6. If eligible, register for disability related accommodations in time for the midterm exam.

Textbook:

The text for this class is *Corporate Finance*. Stephen A. Ross, Randolph W. Westerfield, Jeffrey Jaffe, Bradford Jordan, and Kelly Shue. 2025 Edition or earlier 12th and 13th editions are all fine (these do not have Shue as a co-author).

Course Outline:

Lecture notes for each week will be available on Canvas the Sunday prior to the class meeting.

Week	Topics	Textbook Chapters
1 (16, 18 February)	Time Value of Money	4
2 (23, 25 February)	Capital Budgeting Tools, Bonds	5, 6, 8
3 (2, 4 March)	Equities	9
4 (9, 11 March)	Economy Shipping (Case), Portfolio Theory	10, 11
5 (16, 18 March)	CAPM Zoom Midterm Review: 4pm Sunday March 22nd	12, 13
6 (23, 25 March)	Beta Management (Case), Course Review Midterm exam released after your section's class finishes and the exam must be completed by: 6:00pm Monday March 30th for Section 1 6:00pm Wednesday April 1st for Section 2	-
7 (30 March, 1 April)	Efficient Markets, Behavioral Finance	14
8 (6, 8 April)	Warren Buffet (Case), Financing and Capital Structure	16, 17
9 (13, 15 April)	Boeing 7E7 (Case), Discounted Cash Flows	18
10 (20, 22 April)	Derivatives	7.3, 22, 25
11 (27, 29 April)	Great Recession Zoom Final Review: 4pm Sunday May 3rd	-
12 (4, 6 May)	Special Topics, Course Review Final exam released on Monday May 4th and the exam must be completed by: 11:59pm Wednesday May 13th for Sections 1 & 2	-

Grades:

Graded Assignments	Weight
Midterm Exam	25%
Final Exam	25%
Case 1: Economy Shipping	5%
Case 2: Beta Management	10%
Case 3: Warren Buffet	5%
Case 4: Boeing 7E7	10%
Participation	20%
Total	100%

Cases are in groups.

Exams are open book and a cheat sheet of helpful formula is provided.

Your class letter grade is ultimately determined following the Jones School grading policy for core courses. This requires that no more than half of all grades assigned may be A- or above, and the GPA (combined across all sections) must be between 3.30 and 3.50. If a student receives a grade lower than C, they must repeat the class.

Artificial Intelligence (AI) Policy:

The abilities of AI tools such as ChatGPT are rapidly developing. AI tools can assist learning, but they also commonly make basic mistakes.

You may use AI tools to review concepts learnt in class and for any graded assignments. If you use AI tools, you need to include a disclaimer on how you used it. If I suspect you used AI tools without acknowledgement you will receive a 0.

You may not upload any case materials to AI tools, as this is a breach of copyright: “The use of any materials for training or inputting into generative AI technologies or LLMs without expressed written permission from the copyright holder is strictly prohibited.” <https://hbsp.harvard.edu/copyright-permission/>

Grading Policy:

1. Late assignments are **never** accepted for credit **unless** both (i) there are extenuating circumstances, and (ii) I have granted permission **prior to the due date**.
2. The dates of the midterm and final are scheduled, please plan around them. If you do not submit both the midterm exam and the final exam, you will fail the course.

Re-Grading Policy:

1. Participation grades are discretionary and are therefore not subject to appeal. Partial credit for incorrect answers on graded assignments is given solely at my discretion and are therefore not subject to appeal. Re-grading requests made 8+ days after an assignment was returned to you cannot be appealed.
2. If you decide to request a re-grade, please make a detailed request for a grade revision in writing within seven days of the assignment being returned to you. Carefully explain why you believe the grade is in error. Please submit a request to my Faculty Support Specialist. Requests for re-grades will result in the re-grading of the entire assignment/exam, not just the question(s) at issue. Please note I am probably, on average, a stricter grader than my teaching assistant when offering partial credit for wrong answers. Your grade may therefore be significantly lower after re-grading.

Participation:

You are expected to be on time and seated when class starts. Late arrivals disrupt class, and this will be reflected heavily in your participation grade. **If possible, wait for breaks or the end of class to leave to minimize disruptions.**

Class participation is a fundamental part of this course. You should read the assigned chapters before coming to the lectures. **You should be prepared to answer cold calls. Please always display your name placard with your preferred name.** Your participation grade reflects the whole semester's work, and your grade will not vary if you miss one or two sessions due to illness. Participation grades are primarily based on participation in class, however, productive participation in canvas discussion boards may also be rewarded. Participation grades are not returned to students.

Attendance Policy:

You are expected to attend all class sessions. Students should **not** come to class if they are sick. The grading rubric has accounted for the fact that students may need to miss one or two sessions over the course of the semester for illness, recruiting, or any host of other important events.

It is the policy of the Jones School that if you miss more than two of the twelve classes, your grade will be reduced by one third of a full letter grade per excess absence on a 4.0 grading scale (e.g., from an A to an A-). These grade reductions are in addition to potential class contribution losses associated with missing a class.

Honor Code:

You are expected to always follow the letter and the spirit of the Rice honor code in all your actions throughout the course. You are required to agree to follow the honor pledge on all graded assignments. You may not receive or give any assistance on graded assignments that are outside of the parameters defined explicitly by the course assignments. You may never use or possess any material from past years (quizzes, case reports, problem sets, lecture notes, exams, etc.). Any student who assists you is also in violation. All work in the course is to be completed individually unless otherwise *explicitly* indicated in the assignment instructions. You may not distribute your own notes or class materials to anyone else. On all open book/note exams you are permitted to use any textbook, your own notes, and any materials posted to this course's Canvas page – no other materials are allowed. If any aspect of the honor code is unclear to you at any time it is your responsibility to determine whether your actions are consistent with the honor code.

Audio and Video Recording:

Students may not record audio or video in class under any circumstances.

Cell Phone Classroom Policy:

It is the policy of the Jones School for students to turn their cell phones off during class. Obviously, if something serious is up, talk with me prior to class and keep your cell phone on "vibrate."

Laptop Classroom Policy:

Please bring your laptop to class. You will often need it for doing calculations using excel. Students may use their laptop in the open position during class for annotating notes and calculations.

Disability Based Accommodations:

Any student with a documented disability needing academic adjustments or accommodations is requested to notify me within the first two weeks of class. Students with disabilities should also contact Disability Resource Center in the Allen Center (<https://drc.rice.edu>). All accommodations and adjustments for assignments and exams must be made prior to the graded assignment's deadline.

Religious Accommodations:

Any student that requires accommodation for the observance of religious holidays should coordinate dates with me during the first week of class. Any accommodations or adjustments for assignments must take place prior to the deadline or due date for that assignment.